



English — Cbse English — Combined Half-Yearly (40 Marks)

ANSWER KEY — FOR GRADING

Subject: English | Class: Class 8

Total Marks: 40 | Time Allowed: 1h 30m | CBSE

General Instructions:

1. The paper has four sections: A (Reading), B (Writing), C (Grammar), D (Literature).
2. Sections A-C assess language skills; Section D assesses the prescribed textbook.
3. Attempt all sections. Internal choice is provided in the Writing section.

Q.NO.	QUESTIONS	MARKS
Section A — Reading Attempt all 1 questions. Each carries 10 mark(s).		



Q.NO.	QUESTIONS	MARKS
1	<i>Read the passage carefully and answer the questions that follow.</i> The Plastic We Cannot See When we think of plastic pollution, we picture bottles choking rivers or bags drifting in the sea. Yet, an even more insidious threat often escapes our eyes: microplastics. These are tiny plastic fragments, smaller than five millimetres, that silently infiltrate our soil, water, and eventually our food. Microplastics enter the environment in several unnoticed ways. Synthetic clothing sheds microscopic fibres during every wash, which flow into drains. Personal care products, like face scrubs, once contained microbeads that slipped through water-treatment plants. In agriculture, plastic mulch used to retain soil moisture breaks down over time, leaving behind particles that mix with the earth. Plants absorb these particles, and when animals graze or humans consume these crops, microplastics quietly enter our food chain. The health implications of this invisible invasion are concerning. While scientists are still studying the long-term effects, evidence suggests that microplastics can carry harmful chemicals and may accumulate in human tissues. This is not merely an environmental issue; it is a direct sustainability and health challenge that demands immediate action. Fortunately, everyday choices can significantly reduce this hidden menace. Washing synthetic clothes less frequently, using natural fibre garments like cotton, and avoiding single-use plastics can cut down the shedding of microplastics. Supporting bans on microbeads and choosing products with minimal plastic packaging further limits the flow of these particles into ecosystems. In conclusion, the battle against plastic pollution is not just about cleaning up visible waste. It requires awareness of the plastic we cannot see. By making mindful, sustainable choices today, we can protect both our environment and our health for future generations. (i) What is the central idea of the passage? [1 mark(s)] (A) Microplastics are a hidden but serious threat that requires mindful everyday choices to control. (B) Plastic bottles and bags are the main causes of river and ocean pollution. (C) Scientists have already found a complete cure for the health effects of microplastics. (D) Agriculture is the only source of microplastic pollution in the food chain. Ans: A <i>The passage discusses the unseen danger of microplastics entering our environment and food chain, concluding that mindful, sustainable everyday choices are needed to combat this threat.</i> (ii) According to the passage, how do microplastics enter agricultural soil? [1 mark(s)] (A) Through the breakdown of plastic mulch used for soil moisture. (B) Through microscopic fibres from synthetic clothing.	10



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	(C) Through microbeads from personal care products. (D) Through chemical fertilizers sprayed on crops. Ans: A <i>The passage explicitly states that plastic mulch used to retain soil moisture breaks down over time, leaving behind particles that mix with the earth.</i> (iii) What can be inferred about the current state of scientific knowledge regarding microplastics? [1 mark(s)] (A) Scientists have completely mapped the health effects of microplastics. (B) Scientists have proven that microplastics only affect animals, not humans. (C) Scientists are still investigating the long-term health effects of microplastics. (D) Scientists are certain that microplastics do not affect human tissues. Ans: C <i>The passage mentions that scientists are 'still studying the long-term effects', which implies that the full extent of health impacts is not yet completely known.</i> (iv) Which word from the passage means 'gradually and secretly causing harm'? [1 mark(s)] (A) Infiltrate (B) Insidious (C) Accumulate (D) Shedding Ans: B <i>The word 'insidious' is used in the passage to describe a threat that escapes our eyes and acts secretly, matching the definition of gradually and secretly causing harm.</i> (v) Which everyday choice directly reduces the shedding of microplastics into water systems? [1 mark(s)] (A) Using more plastic mulch in farming. (B) Buying personal care products with microbeads. (C) Avoiding natural fibre garments like cotton. (D) Washing synthetic clothes less frequently. Ans: D <i>The passage states that washing synthetic clothes less frequently can cut down the shedding of microplastics, which otherwise flow into drains.</i> (vi) According to the passage, what are two ways microplastics enter the environment? [1 mark(s)] Ans: Through synthetic clothing shedding fibres and the breakdown of plastic mulch in agriculture. <i>The passage mentions that synthetic clothing sheds fibres during washing and plastic mulch breaks down in the soil as two distinct ways microplastics enter the environment.</i> (vii) Why does the author call microplastic pollution an 'invisible invasion'? [1 mark(s)] Ans: Because the plastic fragments are tiny and silently infiltrate our soil, water, and food without being seen.	



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	<i>The author uses the term 'invisible invasion' because microplastics are smaller than five millimetres and enter our systems silently, escaping human sight.</i> (viii) Why is choosing products with minimal plastic packaging recommended? [1 mark(s)] Ans: It limits the flow of plastic particles into ecosystems. <i>The passage suggests that choosing products with minimal plastic packaging helps limit the flow of microplastic particles into ecosystems, thereby reducing pollution.</i> (ix) How do everyday choices help in reducing microplastics? Explain with two examples from the passage. [2 mark(s)] Ans: Everyday choices reduce the sources of microplastics. For example, using natural fibre garments like cotton reduces shedding from synthetic clothes, and choosing products with minimal plastic packaging limits the flow of particles into ecosystems. <i>The passage highlights that mindful choices like switching to natural fibres and reducing plastic packaging directly cut down the creation and entry of microplastics into the environment.</i>	
Section B — Writing Attempt 1 out of 1.		



Q.NO.	QUESTIONS	MARKS
2	Story Writing Write a story based on the following cues: • Arjun has just moved to a new town and feels lonely. • A sudden storm forces him to take shelter at an old bus stop. • He meets an elderly stranger there, and something unexpected happens. Give your story a suitable title. (Word limit: 95–145 words) <i>(Word limit: 95–145 words; Suggested time: 20 min)</i> Model Answer: The Storm and the Stranger Arjun had been in the new town for only a week and had no friends yet. One evening, walking home from school, the sky turned charcoal-black and a fierce storm erupted. Rain lashed the streets. He sprinted toward the nearest shelter — a crumbling bus stop. An elderly woman was already there, clutching a basket of marigolds. She smiled warmly and offered him a plastic sheet to sit on. "I'm Mrs. Kamat, a flower seller from the next lane," she said. As thunder rumbled, she told him stories about the town — its festivals, its old banyan tree, and the children who played under it. Arjun listened, fascinated. Something warmer grew inside that little bus stop. When the rain stopped, Mrs. Kamat handed him a marigold. "Come visit my shop tomorrow." That stormy evening gave Arjun his first friend in a strange new town. • Arjun is new to the town and has no friends yet • A fierce storm erupts while he is walking home, forcing him to take shelter at a bus stop • He meets an elderly flower seller named Mrs. Kamat who offers him kindness • Mrs. Kamat shares stories about the town, sparking a connection • The storm ends with an invitation and the beginning of an unlikely friendship • Moral: a small act of kindness can turn strangers into friends • Format: 1 mark(s) • Content: 2 mark(s) • Organisation/Expression: 1 mark(s) • Spelling & Grammar: 1 mark(s) OR Paragraph Write a descriptive paragraph (80–100 words) on A Rainy Day that you remember fondly. You may use the following cues:	5



Q.NO.	QUESTIONS	MARKS
	• When and where it happened (e.g., school trip, holiday, sudden shower). • Sensory details — what you saw, heard, smelled, and felt. • What you and others did during or after the rain. • A concluding line on why the day stays in your memory. (Word limit: 70–105 words; Suggested time: 20 min) Model Answer: A rainy day I will never forget was when sudden showers caught us during our school picnic to Lodhi Gardens. Dark clouds gathered quickly, and gentle raindrops turned into a steady downpour. The earthy smell of wet soil filled the air while trees looked freshly washed and green. We ran to a shelter, laughing and splashing through puddles. Our teacher handed out hot samosas and tea, which tasted wonderful in the cool breeze. Classmates sang songs as we watched raindrops dance on the pond. The rain stopped after an hour, leaving a cool, fresh evening. That unexpected shower turned an ordinary picnic into my happiest memory. • Topic sentence introducing a memorable rainy day during a school picnic at Lodhi Gardens • Sensory details — dark clouds, sound of downpour, earthy smell of wet soil, freshly washed green trees • Activities during the rain — running to a shelter, splashing through puddles, hot samosas and tea, classmates singing songs • Concluding line reflecting on how the unexpected shower turned an ordinary picnic into a happy memory • Format: 1 mark(s) • Content: 2 mark(s) • Organisation/Expression: 1 mark(s) • Spelling & Grammar: 1 mark(s)	
Section C — Grammar Attempt all 5 questions. Each carries 1 mark(s).		
3	Unless you submit the assignment by Friday, the teacher ___ marks. [Conditionals] (A) will deduct (B) deducts (C) would deduct (D) had deducted Answer: Correct Option: (A) ► Why? 'Unless' is followed by a present-tense verb, and the main clause expresses a likely future result with 'will + base verb'. 'Deducts' would form a zero conditional (general truth), 'would deduct' is unreal, and 'had deducted' is past.	1
4	A new bridge ___ being constructed across the river to connect the two villages. [Gap Filling] (A) is (B) are (C) was (D) has	1



Q.NO.	QUESTIONS	MARKS
	Answer: Correct Option: (A) ► Why? The subject 'A new bridge' is singular and the action is ongoing in the present, so the present continuous passive 'is being constructed' requires 'is'. 'Are' is plural and does not agree with the singular subject. 'Was' would indicate past continuous, but the context suggests a current, ongoing project. 'Has' does not combine with 'being' to form a correct passive construction.	
5	The jury ___ unable to agree on a verdict after three days of deliberation. [Subject-Verb Concord] (A) was (B) is (C) were (D) has Answer: Correct Option: (C) ► Why? The collective noun 'jury' takes a plural verb 'were' when its members are acting individually and disagreeing with one another, as indicated by 'unable to agree'. 'Was' and 'is' would treat the jury as a unified body, which contradicts the context of disagreement. 'Has' does not fit grammatically before the adjective 'unable'.	1
6	The teacher praised Ravi and ___ for the excellent science project. [Direct & Indirect Objects] (A) I (B) he (C) me (D) she Answer: Correct Option: (C) ► Why? When a pronoun functions as an object (here, the direct object of 'praised'), it must be in the objective case. 'Me' is the objective-case form of 'I'. Subject-case pronouns such as 'I', 'he', and 'she' cannot serve as objects.	1
7	If he ___ the school captain, he would introduce a longer lunch break for everyone. [Conditionals] (A) was (B) is (C) will be (D) were Answer: Correct Option: (D) ► Why? In a second conditional (hypothetical situation), the subjunctive mood requires 'were' for all subjects, including singular ones like 'he'. 'Were' is the formally correct form. 'Was' is a common informal error in written English, 'is' (present tense) would clash with 'would introduce' in the main clause, and 'will be' wrongly introduces a future modal in the if-clause.	1
Section D — Literature Attempt all 10 questions. Each carries 2 mark(s).		



Q.NO.	QUESTIONS	MARKS
8	What does Bibha Chowdhuri's nomination by Erwin Schrödinger tell us about her abilities? Answer: Bibha Chowdhuri's nomination for the Nobel Prize in 1950 by Erwin Schrödinger, a renowned physicist himself, demonstrates that her scientific abilities and contributions were of exceptional calibre, recognised at the highest international level. This nomination by a distinguished scientist indicates that her work on cosmic rays and subatomic particles was considered significant and worthy of the highest honour in science, reflecting her remarkable talent despite the challenges she faced as a woman in a male-dominated field. ► Why? The chapter states that her nomination 'reflected her remarkable talent.' Erwin Schrödinger was a celebrated physicist, and his nomination of Bibha Chowdhuri for the Nobel Prize indicates that her work was recognised and respected by the international scientific community, affirming the quality and importance of her research. ► Step-by-step: 1. Bibha Chowdhuri was nominated for the Nobel Prize in 1950 by Erwin Schrödinger, a renowned physicist 2. This nomination demonstrates that her scientific abilities were of exceptional calibre recognised internationally 3. Her work on cosmic rays and subatomic particles was considered significant and worthy of the highest honour in science 4. The nomination reflects her remarkable talent despite facing challenges as a woman in a male-dominated field [Ch 15: Bibha Chowdhuri: The Beam of Light that Lit the Path for Women in Indian Science]	2
9	Do you think the cherry tree would survive? Why do you think so? Answer: Yes, the cherry tree would survive because it showed remarkable resilience throughout the story. Despite facing multiple challenges—a goat eating its leaves, a woman cutting it with her scythe, and harsh winter snow—it continued to grow back each time. Grandfather also reassured Rakesh that cherry trees are tough, and the tree proved this by sending out new shoots after each setback. ► Why? The chapter demonstrates the cherry tree's resilience. After the goat ate its leaves, new leaves appeared. After being cut by the woman's scythe, it sent out new shoots. Despite harsh winter snow, it survived and eventually blossomed. Grandfather's statement 'cherry trees are tough' is proven true throughout the narrative. ► Step-by-step: 1. The cherry tree demonstrated remarkable resilience throughout the story 2. It survived multiple challenges: a goat eating its leaves, being cut by a woman's scythe, and harsh winter snow 3. The tree continued to grow back after each setback 4. Grandfather reassured Rakesh that cherry trees are tough 5. The tree proved its toughness by sending out new shoots after each challenge	2



Q.NO.	QUESTIONS	MARKS
	[Ch 10: The Cherry Tree]	
10	Irony is a literary device that emphasises the difference between what is expected and what actually happens. It often involves a situation where the outcome is the opposite of what is expected, creating a surprising or a humorous effect. For example, Mrs. Jones' excitement about her garden contrasts with the speaker's disappointment on how ordinary it is. Identify the line(s) from the poem that display(s) situational irony. Answer: The lines displaying situational irony are: 'Where is this lovely thing?' I cried. / 'You're standing on it,' she replied. The irony lies in the contrast between the speaker's expectation of seeing a beautiful, visible flower and the reality that the flower is so tiny that the speaker has been unknowingly standing on it. Mrs. Jones treasures something so small that others cannot even see it, creating a humorous and surprising outcome opposite to expectations. ► Why? Situational irony occurs when the actual outcome differs from what is expected. The speaker expects to see a magnificent flower after Mrs. Jones's enthusiasm, but the flower is so tiny that it's underfoot. This creates humor and highlights the difference between Mrs. Jones's appreciation for small things and the speaker's conventional expectations. ► Step-by-step: 1. Identify the lines from the poem that show situational irony: 'Where is this lovely thing?' I cried. / 'You're standing on it,' she replied. 2. Explain the contrast between the speaker's expectation of a beautiful, visible flower and the reality of a tiny flower underfoot. 3. Highlight how Mrs. Jones's appreciation for something so small creates humor and surprises the speaker. [Ch 2: A Concrete Example]	2
11	What is the difference between a fact and an opinion? Explain with examples. Answer: A fact is something that can be proven true or false and is not based on people's beliefs. For example, 'Encyclopedia's father was the Chief of Police' is a fact because it can be verified. An opinion, on the other hand, is a belief, feeling, or judgement that can vary from one person to another. An opinion cannot be proven. For instance, 'Everyone thought that Chief Brown must be the smartest police chief in the country' is an opinion because it reflects personal judgement rather than verifiable truth. Facts remain constant, while opinions differ among individuals.	2



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	► Why? The answer clearly distinguishes between facts and opinions using definitions from the source and provides relevant examples from the story. ► Step-by-step: 1. Step 1: Define what a fact is according to the source. 2. Step 2: Define what an opinion is according to the source. 3. Step 3: Give examples from the text to illustrate both concepts. [Ch 7: The Case of the Fifth Word]	
12	How can we say that the grandmother shared her husband's dedication to a greater cause? Answer: The grandmother shared her husband's dedication to a greater cause by choosing to support his decision to work in Anand, despite knowing that life there would lack even the simple comforts they took for granted elsewhere. She 'ardently supported' his choice to live and work for the dairy farmers' cooperative, demonstrating her commitment to his mission of serving the nation's farmers. ► Why? The chapter describes how the grandmother made an 'important choice' to stand by Dr. Kurien despite the hardships of life in Anand. Her support was not passive acceptance but 'ardent' (enthusiastic) support, showing she shared his vision of serving the farmers and building the nation. ► Step-by-step: 1. The grandmother made a conscious choice to support her husband's decision to work in Anand despite the hardships 2. She understood that life in Anand would lack even the basic comforts they enjoyed elsewhere 3. Her support was 'ardent' (enthusiastic), not merely passive acceptance 4. This demonstrated her shared commitment to the mission of serving the nation's farmers [Ch 6: Verghese Kurien—I Too Had A Dream]	2
13	What does the crew's action of passing the oxygen bottle around 'like a pipe of peace' suggest about their response to the situation? Answer: The comparison of passing the oxygen bottle around 'like a pipe of peace' suggests that the crew was trying to maintain calm and unity during a crisis. A 'pipe of peace' is traditionally shared to establish harmony and resolve conflicts. This phrase refers to a Native American tradition of sharing a ceremonial pipe to cement friendships and resolve disputes. By sharing the oxygen bottle in this manner, the crew was collectively coping with the emergency, supporting each other, and trying to stay composed while waiting for Jim to investigate the air quality issue. This action demonstrates their cooperative spirit and mutual support during a frightening situation where they realized their lives might be in danger.	2



Q.NO.	QUESTIONS	MARKS
	► Why? The phrase 'pipe of peace' refers to a Native American tradition of sharing a ceremonial pipe to cement friendships and resolve disputes. By comparing the oxygen bottle to this symbol, the author suggests the crew found comfort and solidarity in sharing this life-sustaining resource. It shows their cooperative spirit and mutual support during a frightening situation where they realized their lives might be in danger. ► Step-by-step: 1. The comparison to 'pipe of peace' suggests the crew was trying to maintain calm and unity during a crisis 2. A 'pipe of peace' is a Native American tradition for establishing harmony and resolving conflicts 3. Sharing the oxygen bottle showed collective coping, mutual support, and cooperative spirit during the emergency 4. The crew found comfort and solidarity in sharing this life-sustaining resource while waiting for Jim to investigate [Ch 13: Feathered Friend]	
14	How was the boy's approach towards the old woman different from that of the other boys in the group? Answer: While the other boys in the group 'hastened' past the old woman, 'Nor offered a helping hand to her', and were busy enjoying their freedom after school, the boy paused beside her and 'whispered low' to offer help. The other boys were indifferent and focused on their own enjoyment, but the boy noticed the woman's need, stopped to help her, and treated her with respect and kindness by speaking gently to her. ► Why? The poem contrasts the behaviour of the group of boys with the single boy who stops to help. While the group is described as 'Glad in the freedom of school let out' and 'Hailing the snow piled white and deep,' the helpful boy pauses and shows concern for the elderly woman. ► Step-by-step: 1. Other boys 'hastened' past the old woman without offering help 2. Other boys were focused on enjoying their freedom after school 3. The boy paused beside the woman and 'whispered low' to offer help 4. Other boys showed indifference while the boy showed concern 5. The boy noticed the woman's need and treated her with respect and kindness [Ch 5: Somebody's Mother]	2
15	Have you ever waited for the rains? Why? Answer: Yes, I have waited for the rains many times. During summer, the heat becomes unbearable and everyone looks forward to the monsoon season. The rains bring relief from the scorching heat, cool down the environment, and replenish water sources. Farmers especially wait for rains as their crops depend on it.	2



Q.NO.	QUESTIONS	MARKS
	► Why? This is a personal reflection question that prepares students for the chapter theme. The chapter 'Waiting for the Rain' explores the anxiety and hope associated with waiting for rainfall, particularly from a farmer's perspective. ► Step-by-step: 1. Personal experience of waiting for rains during summer 2. Monsoon season brings relief from unbearable heat 3. Rains cool the environment and replenish water sources 4. Farmers depend on rains for their crops [Ch 12: Waiting for the Rain]	
16	Intonation is the rise and fall of the pitch of tone while speaking. The 'falling' tone is the fall in the pitch of the voice from a high level to a low level. It is marked [→]. The falling tone is generally used in imperative sentences. Read the following sentences from the text with the falling tone. Answer: Students should practice reading the sentences 'Come here!', 'Seize this magic brush...', 'Paint my fortress tall!', and 'Go and fetch some rice.' with a falling tone, where the voice pitch drops from high to low. The falling tone conveys commands, instructions, or warnings, making these imperative sentences sound authoritative and firm. ► Why? The chapter teaches intonation patterns, specifically the falling tone used in imperative sentences. Students practice reading commands from the poem with appropriate falling intonation to convey authority and firmness. ► Step-by-step: 1. Practice reading the given sentences with a falling tone where voice pitch drops from high to low 2. The falling tone is used to convey commands, instructions, or warnings 3. Imperative sentences sound authoritative and firm when read with falling intonation [Ch 8: The Magic Brush of Dreams]	2
17	What might be the writer's purpose of highlighting the awe-inspiring natural wonders of India? Answer: The writer's purpose in highlighting India's awe-inspiring natural wonders is to showcase the mystique and diversity of India's landscapes, educate readers about rare natural phenomena, and foster appreciation for the country's geological and ecological heritage. By describing phenomena like the Valley of Flowers, Living Root Bridges, and Magnetic Hills, the writer aims to spark curiosity, challenge readers' understanding of the natural world, and remind them of the extraordinary forces that shape our environment, blending scientific intrigue with cultural significance.	2



Q.NO.	QUESTIONS	MARKS
	► Why? The concluding paragraph states that 'These awe-inspiring natural wonders of India highlight the mystique of the country's landscapes, each phenomenon telling its own story of nature's artistic flair and enigmatic charm. They challenge our understanding of the natural world and captivate our senses. They serve as a reminder of the extraordinary forces that shape our environment, blending scientific intrigue with the magic of folklore.' ► Step-by-step: 1. Showcasing the mystique and diversity of India's landscapes 2. Educating readers about rare natural phenomena 3. Fostering appreciation for the country's geological and ecological heritage 4. Describing specific examples like Valley of Flowers, Living Root Bridges, and Magnetic Hills to spark curiosity 5. Challenging readers' understanding of the natural world 6. Reminding readers of the extraordinary forces that shape our environment 7. Blending scientific intrigue with cultural significance [Ch 9: Spectacular Wonders]	

